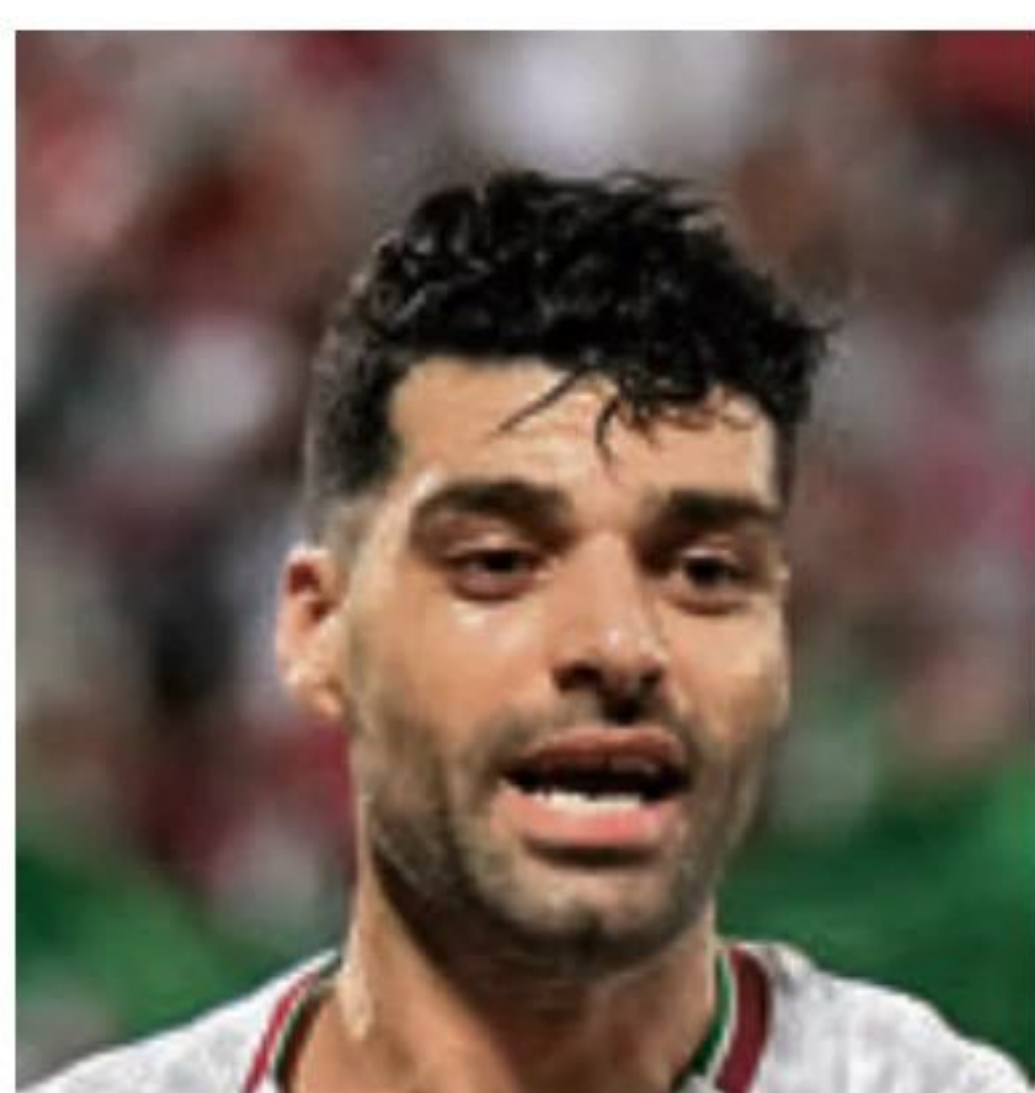


brings valuable tournament experience in goal, and the side is typically compact, physical and difficult to break down. The opener against New Zealand is crucial. Win it, and Iran can turn the Egypt match into a knockout shootout. Drop points, and the group becomes unforgiving.

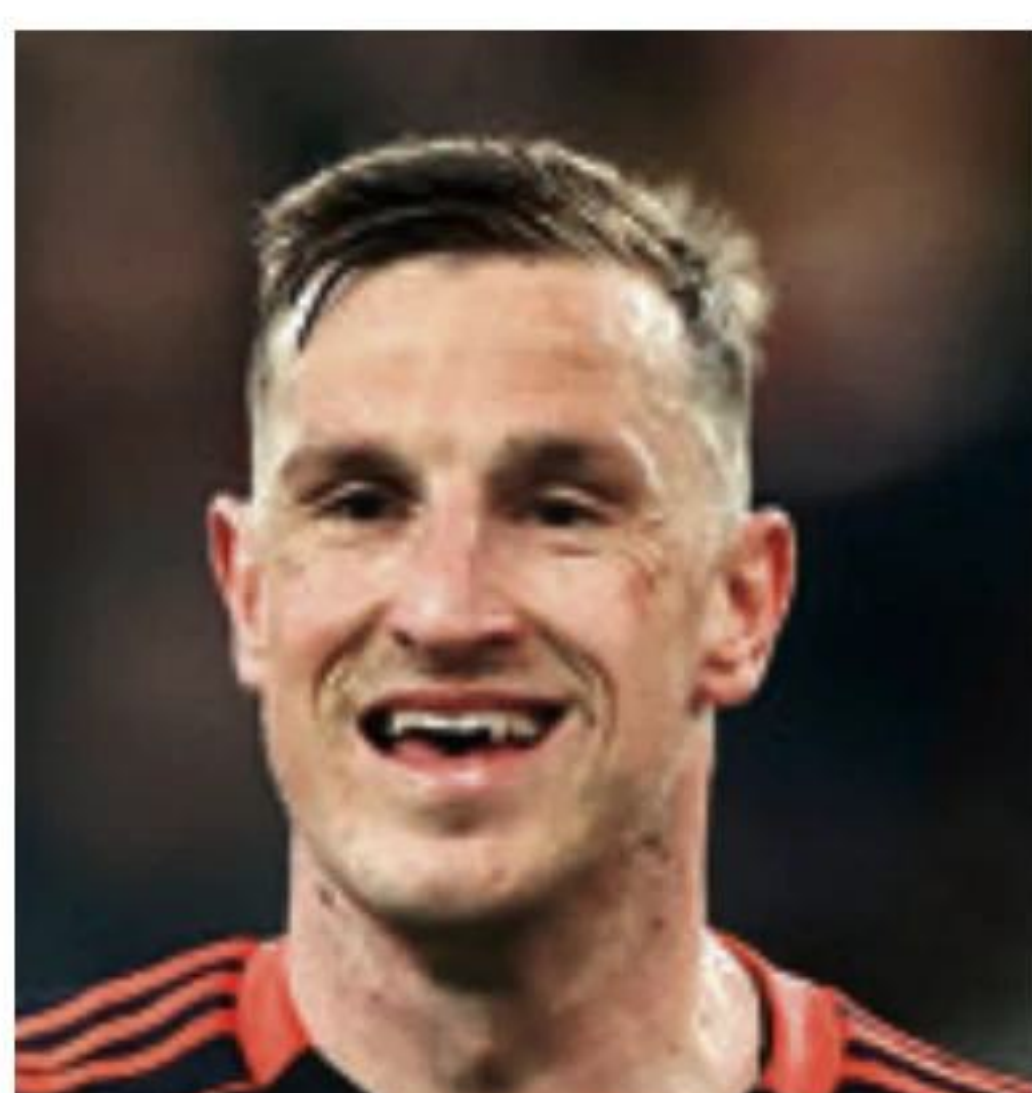
New Zealand is the clear outsider, but not without a compelling story. The All Whites are back at the World Cup for the first time since 2010, when they went unbeaten yet exited in the group stage. Chris Wood gives coach Darren Bazeley a proven goalscorer and leader. The team has cohesion and a strong Oceania qualifying campaign behind it, but Belgium, Egypt and Iran represent a significant step up in quality. Its best chance of staying alive is to take something from Iran in Los Angeles.

Group G should belong to Belgium, but it may not be straightforward. Egypt has enough attacking quality to challenge for first place, Iran has sufficient structure to punish lapses, and New Zealand has little to lose. Belgium remains the favourite. The real contest may be for second place, where Egypt's Salah-Marmoush axis and Iran's tournament expertise could make this one of the most intriguing tactical battles of the group stage.



Mehdi Taremi
(Iran)

Taremi gives Iran experience, movement and composure in the final third. He can operate as a centre-forward or link attacks from deeper positions. In a group where margins could be fine, his finishing may determine whether Iran reaches the knockout rounds.



Chris Wood
(New Zealand)

Wood is New Zealand's captain, record goalscorer and best hope of turning pressure into goals. Strong in the air and efficient in the penalty area, he gives the All Whites a clear focal point against stronger teams likely to dominate possession.

SQUADS

Belgium

Goalkeepers: Thibaut Courtois, Senne Lammens, Mike Penders

Defenders: Timothy Castagne, Zeno Debast, Maxim de Cuyper, Koni De Winter, Brandon Mechele, Thomas Meunier, Nathan Ngoy, Joaquin Seys, Arthur Theate

Midfielders: Kevin De Bruyne, Amadou Onana, Nicolas Raskin, Youri Tielemans, Hans Vanaken, Axel Witsel

Forwards: Charles De Ketelaere, Jeremy Doku, Matias Fernandez-Pardo, Romelu Lukaku, Dodi Lukebakio, Diego Moreira, Alexis Saelemaekers, Leandro Trossard

Egypt

Goalkeepers: Mohamed El Shenawy, Mostafa Shobeir, El Mahdi Soliman, Mohamed Alaa

Defenders: Mohamed Abdelmonem, Mohamed Hany, Yasser Ibrahim, Hossam Abdelmaguid, Ahmed Fatouh, Tarek Alaa, Ramy Rabia, Hamdy Fathy, Karim Hafez

Midfielders: Mohamed Salah, Marwan Attia, Ahmed Sayed 'Zizo, Mahmoud Hassan 'Trezeguet', Emam Ashour, Mostafa Ziko, Mohanad Lasheen, Haissem Hassan, Mahmoud Saber, Ibrahim Adel, Nabil Emad

Forwards: Omar Marmoush, Hamza Abdelkarim

Iran

Goalkeepers: Alireza Beiranvand, Seyed Hossein Hosseini, Payam Niazmand

Defenders: Danial Eiri, Ehsan Hajsafi, Saleh Hardani, Hossein Kanaani, Shoja Khalilzadeh, Milad Mohammadi, Ali Nemat, Ramin Rezaeian

Midfielders: Rouzbeh Cheshmi, Saeid Ezatolahi, Mehdi Ghaedi, Saman Ghoddos, Mohammad Ghorbani, Alireza Jahanbakhsh, Mohammad Mohebi, Amir Mohammad Razzaghinia, Mehdi Torabi, Aria Yousefi

Forwards: Ali Alipour, Dennis Dargahi, Amirhossein Hosseinzadeh, Mehdi Taremi, Shahriar Moghanlou

New Zealand

Goalkeepers: Max Crocombe, Alex Paulsen, Michael Woud

Defenders: Tyler Bindon, Michael Boxall, Liberato Cacace, Francis de Vries, Callan Elliot, Tim Payne, Nando Pijnaker, Tommy Smith, Finn Surman

Midfielders: Lachlan Bayliss, Joe Bell, Matthew Garbett, Ben Old, Alex Rufer, Sarpreet Singh, Marko Stamenic, Ryan Thomas, Eli Just, Callum McCowatt

Forwards: Kosta Barbarouses, Jesse Randall, Ben Waine, Chris Wood